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FACTORS INFLUENCING NONPROFIT RESOURCE PROVIDER SUPPORT DECISIONS: APPLYING THE BRAND EQUITY CONCEPT TO NONPROFITS

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This exploratory research examines the influence of antecedent factors on resource provider (volunteers and donors) based brand equity for a nonprofit organization. The study, utilizing a telephone survey, applies brand equity for the first time to the nonprofit sector and provides initial empirical evidence of the multidimensional influence of brand personality, brand image, and brand awareness antecedents of the resource providers' biased decision to support the nonprofit organization after controlling for the influence of altruistic volunteerism. This extension of the branding literature is adapted from the much more common customer-based conceptualizations of Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993). The results suggest an opportunity for nonprofits to compete for these vital resources by nurturing and leveraging the antecedent factors which create resource provider based brand equity.

INTRODUCTION

Nonprofit services -- frequently called "public" or "collective goods" (Weisbrod 1977) -- rely on 20 billion volunteer hours and \$200 billion in private charitable gifts annually (Hodgkinson, Nelson, and Sivak 2002; Salamon 2002). Even with this level of generosity, nonprofits have historically been strapped for both human and financial resources (Salamon 2002). Moreover, the resource squeeze has been exacerbated by cutbacks in federal financial support (Salamon 2002), a drop in private and corporate giving (Hodgkinson, Nelson, and Sivak 2002; Porter and Kramer 2002), increased competition for the same resources from for-profits and other nonprofits (Cellucci 1998; Salamon 2002), and resource provider lifestyle changes and resource constraints (Porter and Kramer 2002). Instructively, one study indicated most nonprofit executives spend almost half their time seeking resources (Sinha 1997). Given these nonprofit resource challenges, there is a need to understand how nonprofits can better address the marketing practices that could be used to secure resources from donors and volunteers.

In response to the resource challenges many nonprofits have increased their marketing and sales activities (Frumkin and Kim 2001; Arnold and Tapp 2003). Unfortunately, increased effort alone may not meet these recent challenges. It may be necessary to re-think, at a strategic and conceptual level, how

to influence public opinion and support behavior regarding nonprofits. For example, the Consultancy Interbrand Group recognized early-on that nonprofits fail to utilize brand marketing and established a foundation to help nonprofits develop branding strategies to meet their resource challenges (Beardi 1999). However, there is little empirical work to support this branding approach or to guide nonprofit managers. The purpose of the present research is three-fold: 1) extend brand equity concepts developed in the for-profit sector to a nonprofit setting; 2) demonstrate the importance of measuring and distinguishing the antecedent factors of brand equity which influence biased resource provider support for the nonprofit; and 3) suggest preliminary application of these findings to nonprofit marketing practices. Initially, major concepts in the brand equity literature will be reviewed, linked to nonprofit marketing practices, and then used to develop a series of testable hypotheses.

This exploratory research provides two contributions to the extant branding and brand equity literature. First, antecedents and their dimensions that influence resource provider based brand equity are demonstrated. These antecedents, while frequently conjectured to influence brand equity, have not been empirically demonstrated within the context of a brand equity based model. Secondly, brand equity and its antecedents have not been significantly discussed or empirically applied in the nonprofit literature. An empirical

application is reported here. The paper briefly reviews the current status of nonprofit marketing and branding literature, presents hypotheses of the multidimensional influence of brand image, brand personality, and brand awareness antecedents of the resource provider decision after controlling for respondents' altruistic volunteerism, describes the research design, and discusses the study's results and implications.

Brand Equity

For years the brand equity concept has received considerable attention in the marketing literature, providing a model for organizations to conceptualize and manage brand development (Aaker 1991; Keller 1993; Cuneo 1999).

Keller (1993) believes customer-based brand equity arises from a more favorable differential response to the firm's brand marketing efforts. According to Keller (1993) customer-based brand equity is a bias to behave toward the brand, which is the construct definition adopted for this study. Brand equity is often associated with enhanced brand choice probability (Holden 1992) and willingness of consumers to pay premium prices (e.g., Farquhar 1989; Aaker 1991).

Brand equity research has also examined antecedents to the construct. Brand image, a multidimensional construct (Malhotra 1981), is generally seen as the combined effect of all brand associations on the consumer's perception of the brand (e.g., Dobni and Zinkhan 1990). In other words, it is the overall mental image the consumer holds regarding the brand and can be seen in isolation or in relation to other brands. This is the brand image conceptual definition adopted for this study. Keller (1993) views brand image as the perceptual beliefs about a brand's attribute, benefit, and attitude associations, which are frequently seen as the basis for an overall evaluation of the brand. This notion is consistent with Holden (1992), who finds brand equity is also facilitated by brand awareness or the increased propensity for the brand to be evoked from memory.

Another model which includes brand associations, brand loyalty, brand awareness, and perceived quality as antecedents of brand equity has been presented (Aaker 1991). However, the nomological network surrounding brand equity is not fully fleshed out (Shocker 1993). For example, the brand personality construct has sometimes been used interchangeably with brand image (e.g., Dobni and Zinkhan 1990; Batra, Lehmann, and Singh 1993), but some argue, while it is a dimension of brand image, it has significance and face validity in its own right (Aaker 1996). In spite of this confusion, one issue is clear – each is an antecedent factor to brand equity. Recognizing these distinct brand equity antecedents may be critical to marketing efforts for nonprofits.

For nonprofits, the traditional firm based approach (Keller 1993) which examines the financial consequences of brand equity may not be as beneficial as Keller's customer-based

approach which identifies how antecedents to brand equity create biased support among volunteers and donors. Importantly, Keller conceptualizes brand equity's biased behavior as manifested in ways other than just purchase, such as, brand loyalty, willingness to pay premium prices, brand attitudes, etc. If nonprofits manage marketing efforts that convey the brand equity antecedents (positive images and personalities, greater awareness and familiarity) to potential resource providers they are more likely to become volunteers or donors. Why would this be true? Simply put, nonprofits must manage relationships so that volunteers and donors see value in that interaction. This is close to Keller's (1993) conceptualization of customer-based brand equity as a bias to behave toward the brand which is a consequence of managing the elements that create brand equity in the first place.

In sum, brand equity is a stable and important construct for understanding and managing consumer behavior in for-profit marketing organizations. It has likely import for the nonprofit sector, particularly the idea of managing the antecedents of brand equity. The current challenge is defining and measuring these antecedent constructs and demonstrating the positive support bias that can arise from them. This approach also fits the current challenges faced by nonprofits.

Brand Equity in the Nonprofit Sector

The challenge of increasing resource provider participation when fifty percent of Americans already volunteer with nonprofits each week is immense (e.g., Bonjean, Markham, and Macken 1994; Harrison 1995), and several commentators have focused on the problems of tight budgets and volunteer recruitment (e.g., Cnaan and Goldberg-Glen 1991; Brightman 1994; Coolson and Wintz 1998; Forsyth 1999). Due to the large number of volunteering opportunities, nonprofits' image and its communication to potential volunteers have become increasingly important influences on support behavior (Coolson and Wintz 1998). In response, nonprofits have increased their marketing efforts (e.g., Brightman 1994; Lauer 1995; Bendapudi, Singh, and Bendapudi 1996; Reed 1996; Gilbert 2000), particularly with respect to encouraging volunteering (e.g., Cousins 1990). In addition, researchers and practitioners are considering the concept of branding as a means to address these competitive resource challenges (e.g., Harrison 1996; Feder 1998; Beardi 1999; Gilbert 2000).

However, a review of important texts about nonprofit challenges (e.g., Weisbrod 1998; Light 2002; Salamon 2002) and journals, such as, *Nonprofit Management and Leadership*, *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly*, and the *Journal of Nonprofit and Public Sector Marketing* yields little note of branding strategies and practically no mention of brand equity. A book chapter (Smith 1997) does discuss how to build nonprofit brands, and some published research has indirect implications for understanding nonprofit brand equity. For example, Voss and Voss (2000) suggested the need to apply mainstream marketing concepts to different contexts such as

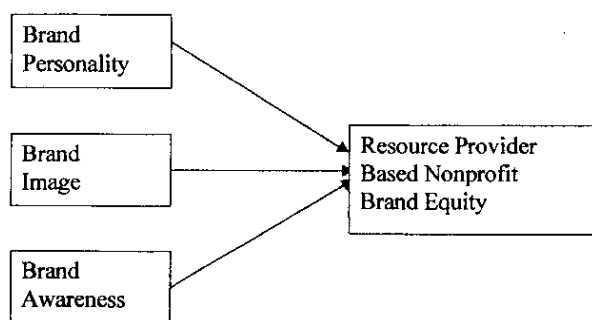
nonprofits. Another study (Bhattacharya, Rao, and Glynn 1995) reported the importance of various correlates with how much one identifies with a nonprofit art museum (brand). The most important predictor was prestige of the museum. This study concluded by noting the importance of future research examining the antecedents of identification (a type of supportive behavior) toward the nonprofit. Also, Venable, Rose, and Gilbert (2003) found nonprofit brand personality traits allowed individuals to differentiate nonprofits across product categories.

Taken as a whole, the scant attention given to nonprofit brand equity research suggests a gap in the literature. The present study is designed to fill a small portion of that gap, focusing on how factors antecedent to brand equity influence positive bias or support toward a nonprofit.

HYPOTHESES

A resource provider based nonprofit brand equity conceptual model is provided in Figure 1. Drawing from their consideration in the for-profit branding literature, the multidimensional influences of brand personality, brand image, and brand awareness on nonprofit brand equity are hypothesized. The effect of these brand equity antecedents is considered after controlling for altruistic volunteerism. This procedure is important because the study focuses on brand equity antecedents which are subject to marketing efforts, while altruistic volunteerism is not.

FIGURE 1
NONPROFIT BRAND EQUITY CONCEPTUAL MODEL



Influence of Brand Personality on Brand Equity

Brand personality provides a uniqueness that can allow consumers to distinguish a nonprofit brand from competitors (Venable, Rose, and Gilbert 2003). A brand's personality develops from all the contacts consumers have with the brand and its marketing activities and is particularly important in symbolic brand use, frequently driving consumer preference (Aaker 1997). While brand personality has often been connected to assigning human characteristics to a brand (e.g.,

Aaker 1997), some recent literature has reframed brand personality in terms of multidimensional brand relationships (Aaker 1996; Fournier 1998; Keller 2003; Aaker, Fournier, and Brasel 2004). The relationship framed personality traits one could associate with a nonprofit brand is how this study operationalizes the brand personality construct. Fournier (1998) claims consumers in a dyadic relationship with brands make inferences about the brand that can be captured in relationship terms and language. Thus, "Summarizing brand personalities in terms of relationship role perceptions....may prove rich in its insight and relevant in its strategic application" (Fournier 1998, p. 368). Nevertheless, Aaker (1997) claims an understanding of how and why brand personality acts as an antecedent to biased preference is unclear. One theory, brand congruence, suggests when a brand's personality matches a consumer's self-concept, preference is enhanced (e.g. Sirgy 1982). Thus, consumers may be inclined to purchase products and services that match their own sense of self. A brand personality that is strong, favorable, and/or unique to the consumer legitimates the brand as partner and can result in more positive reciprocal exchanges (Fournier 1998). For example, in this study a nonprofit brand is perceived as a trustworthy partner or possesses an interesting background which allows consumers to feel more comfortable with the brand and form brand preferences or purchase intentions. Failure to create strong brand personalities has been cited as a problem in growing nonprofits (e.g., Harrison 1995; Feder 1998). Finally, creation of brand personality dimensions of brand respect and brand differentiation provide a basis for relationship building essential to nonprofits achieving resource provider support. This leads to the following hypotheses:

- H1a:** Respondents tend to be more interested in providing resources to nonprofits when they have respect for the nonprofit.
- H1b:** Respondents tend to be more interested in providing resources to nonprofits when they believe the nonprofit is different from other nonprofits.

Influence of Brand Image on Brand Equity

Without a favorable brand image, it is unlikely the firm can create consumer purchase intentions or biased behavior (Gensch 1978; Hunt and Keaveney 1994; Kotler 1997). The ability of brand image to serve as a heuristic for enhanced consumer decision making has been noted in the literature (e.g., Han 1989; Haugtvedt, Leavitt, and Schneider 1993). Marketing researchers suggested brand image is a vital element of brand equity (Aaker 1991; Biel 1993; Keller 1993). Research reported more positive brand image is positively related to willingness to pay premium prices and higher brand equity (e.g., Lassar, Mittal, and Sharma 1995; Faircloth, Capella, and Alford 2001).

Lauer (1995, p. 51) contends a brand identity or image "...can communicate a certain distinctiveness that will have a positive

effect on people's perception of your (nonprofit) organization." Communicating a brand image to resource providers is important, since identification with nonprofit goals and values is a significant contributor to positively biased support behavior toward the nonprofits by consumers (Smith 1997). Resource providers who perceive the nonprofit has strong brand character and brand scale appropriate to mission challenges will be inclined to support the organization. This leads to the following hypotheses:

- H2a:** Respondents tend to be more interested in providing resources to nonprofits when they believe the nonprofit has brand character.
- H2b:** Respondents tend to be more interested in providing resources to nonprofits when they believe the nonprofit has appropriate brand scale.

Influence of Brand Awareness on Brand Equity

Rossiter and Percy (1987) claim brand awareness is the consumer's capability for recalling or recognizing from memory the subject brand in the product category. Brand awareness, a brand equity asset noted by Aaker (1991), helps to ensure the brand is available, either through recall or recognition for consideration in consumer decision making. Top of mind awareness increases the probability of being chosen by the consumer, since a brand not considered will not be chosen. Cato (1993, p.4-5) argues "Widespread public awareness...translates into more members, volunteers, and donations." The importance of another dimension of brand awareness, familiarity, has been reported (Churchill and Iacobucci 2002). Aaker (1996) contends traditional measures of awareness focusing only on recall/recognition miss the dimension of what consumers know about the brand. Bhattacharya, Rao, and Glynn (1995) suggest marketing related programs help consumers understand and identify with the purpose of nonprofits. Thus, one would expect memory recall and greater organizational familiarity by resource providers to increase supportive behavior toward the nonprofit. This leads to the following hypotheses:

- H3a:** Respondents tend to be more interested in providing resources to nonprofits when they have first recall of the nonprofit in the product category.
- H3b:** Respondents tend to be more interested in providing resources to the nonprofit when they are familiar with the nonprofit.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Preliminary Research

An opportunity to apply the brand equity concept to the nonprofit sector was sponsored by a disguised nonprofit organization. This nonprofit organization provides services, support, and self-advocacy training to clients (and their families) with developmental disabilities. Through this project

the organization was attempting to develop a more aggressive resource provider support marketing strategy because of the rumored loss of a significant current income source. The organization was concerned about their community image and awareness, and after meeting with the researcher, believed the brand equity construct applied to their situation.

In order to better understand how the nonprofits' target population might respond to the brand equity focus and issues involved in increasing resource provider support, a series of depth interviews and focus groups were initially conducted by the author. Depth interviews were held with randomly chosen agency members and were designed to identify specific attitudes, images, and perceptions of the agency. The issues identified in the depth interviews were next used as a basis for a series of three focus groups. The first focus group consisted of current members of the agency. Subsequently, two sessions were held with local residents who responded to a classified ad for participation. From these qualitative research activities, research methods and questions and research constructs were refined. In particular, the brand equity construct and antecedents were examined in the preliminary research for appropriateness within the nonprofit context. This preliminary research suggested it was appropriate. A draft of the survey instrument was pre-tested with twenty randomly chosen individuals from the city's telephone directory. Several modifications were made to the wording in the proposed instrument as a result of the pre-testing.

Sampling and Data Collection

The nonprofit agency wanted to expand its marketing efforts to potential members and resource providers and considered residents of a mid-sized Midwestern city aged 21 and up its target population. The sample frame of adults with telephone listings was considered representative of the agency's target membership population. The researchers hoped to complete at least 200 surveys. Data were collected through a telephone survey involving adults (over 21 years old) during a one month period by means of a systematic sampling of the city's telephone directory by four trained M.B.A. students. Respondents were chosen through a process of randomly selecting a starting point and then picking every 10th name thereafter. The interviewer asked to speak to a household resident who was at least 21 years old. Most calls were made between 7 PM and 9 PM during the week. A total of 214 responses were obtained, but for data analysis, 29 respondents who did not recognize the focal organization in a brand awareness recognition measure were eliminated. The response rate, based on whether a potential respondent was actually reached (approximately 500), was 45 percent.

Respondent Profiles

The respondents were 59% female; well educated with almost 82% having more than a high school education; over 50% were working fulltime; 56% were between 26 and 50 year old;

TABLE 1
MEASUREMENT SCALES AND ITEMS

Brand Personality	(7-point Likert scale, 1=strongly disagree to 7=strongly agree,)
Brand Respect	I admire the Arc; I would be proud to be associated with the Arc; The Arc is an organization I would trust
Brand Differentiation	I have a clear image of the Arc's constituents; The Arc is different from other nonprofits; The Arc has a rich history All items adapted from Aaker (1996)
Brand Image	(7-point semantic differential scale) Please indicate your impression of the (organization):
Brand Character	Honest-Dishonest; Fair-Unfair; Valuable-Worthless; Kind-Cruel; Brave-Cowardly; Thrifty-Indulgent; Contemporary-Uncontemporary; Modest-Vain
Brand Scale	Rich-Poor; Large-Small; Excitable-Calm; Dominating-Submissive All items from Malhotra (1981)
Brand Awareness	(First recall and 7-point semantic differential scales)
First Recall	List 3 agencies in (city) that deal with people with mental retardation (listed first) Item adapted from Aaker (1996)
Familiarity	In general, how do you consider yourself in regards to the (organization)? Familiar-Unfamiliar; Highly informed-Not at all informed; Know a great deal-Know nothing at all Items adapted from Oliver and Bearden (1985) How do you rate your knowledge of the (organization) relative to your friends? A great deal of knowledge-Little or no knowledge Item adapted from Bloch et al. (1989)
Brand Equity	(7-point semantic differential and 7-point Likert scale, 1=strongly disagree to 7=strongly agree,) How would you describe your intentions to join the (organization)? Join Likely-Join Unlikely; Join Probable-Join Improbable; Join Possible-Join Impossible; Items adapted from MacKenzie et al. (1986) I would be willing to pay a larger than average organization membership fee to join the Arc Item adapted from Park and Srinivasan (1994) Membership in the Arc would provide good value for my money Item adapted from Aaker (1996)
Volunteerism	(7-point Likert scale, 1=strongly disagree to 7=strongly agree)
Volunteer	People could always find some time to donate to nonprofit organizations if they really wanted to; Donating time to a volunteer organization is not a waste of my time; Items adapted from Wells and Tigert (1971)
Activcivic	I am very active in civic and community affairs Item adapted from Yavas and Riechen (1985)

and 50% had annual incomes between \$20,000 and \$60,000. The demographic profile generally met the expectations for the nonprofit's targeted population. Additionally, the respondents were a reasonably close approximation to those who volunteer in the United States (United States Census Bureau 2002).

Scale Development and Measures

All scales necessary to measure the constructs in the proposed conceptual model—brand personality, brand image, brand

awareness, brand equity, and volunteerism (control variables)—were taken directly from or adapted from existing literature and are described in Table 1. All utilized scales approximately met the .60 composite reliability threshold suggested by Bagozzi and Yi (1988). Following is a discussion of each of these scales.

Brand personality. The brand personality measurement items used in this study were adapted from suggestions made by Aaker (1996). The items used to measure brand personality

capture the relationship building aspect of the construct (Fournier 1998) and its multidimensionality (Aaker 1997). These researchers place the respondent in a dyad with the brand. Fournier's (1998) dimensions of brand relationship quality of love/passion, self-connection, commitment, interdependency, and intimacy are captured in the items utilized here. For example, by framing individual items in a relationship context, such as, "I admire the (organization)" which represents Fournier's dimension of love/passion (affect) or "I trust the (organization)" which suggests the dimension of self-connection, the brand personality/relationship context is manifest. A close examination of the items in brand personality suggested a first dimension of brand respect (composite reliability=.80) and a second dimension of brand differentiation (composite reliability=.67). All items were measured with a 7-point Likert scale (1=strongly disagree to 7=strongly agree).

Brand image- The brand image scale used in this study was developed by Malhotra (1981) and is based upon Osgood, Suci, and Tannenbaum's (1957) attitude measurement research. Malhotra asserts it can be applied to a wide variety of product concepts and it specifically applies to the holistic perception and belief based brand image definition adopted for this study. The original multidimensional 15-item semantic differential scale (for example, honest—dishonest, fair—unfair, etc) was found to have adequate test-retest reliability, internal consistency, and content, convergent and discriminant validity (Malhotra 1981). In this study using a 7-point semantic differential scale eleven of the items loaded cleanly and significantly on two factors. A close examination of the items in brand image appear to consistently represent a dimension of brand character (composite reliability=.89) and a dimension of brand scale (composite reliability=.58).

Brand awareness -Aaker (1996) contends brand awareness has multiple dimensions—knowledge/familiarity and recall/recognition of the brand. For this study a 3-item semantic differential scale, developed by Oliver and Bearden (1985), and a 1-item semantic differential scale developed by Bloch, Ridgway, and Sherrell (1989) were adapted to measure the dimension of nonprofit brand familiarity. The resulting variable, familiarity (composite reliability=.90), was created by totaling and averaging the four items in the two original scales. The second dimension of awareness (recall/recognition) was measured with a 1-item first recall measure suggested by Aaker (1996). The variable, first recall, measured first recall of the brand in the focal nonprofit's product/service class.

Brand equity -Brand equity has frequently been suggested to represent biased or enhanced choice behavior and willingness of the consumer to pay premium prices (e.g., Aaker 1992; Holden 1992; Keller 1993; Ailawadi, Lehmann, and Neslin 2003). Purchase intentions (brand equity measure suggested by Aaker 1996), a common measure of enhanced choice behavior, has been operationalized by MacKenzie, Lutz, and Belch (1986) in a 7-point 3-item (likely/unlikely,

probable/improbable, and possible/impossible) semantic differential scale (average alpha=.89). This research utilized the MacKenzie, Lutz, and Belch (1986) purchase intentions measure. A general measure of the premium a consumer is willing to pay for a particular brand, based upon a comparison to another brand, has been reported (Park and Srinivasan 1994). This scale was modified for the current study into a 7-point single item semantic differential—willingness to pay a premium price (very likely/very unlikely). Finally, "membership in the (organization) would provide a good value for my money" was measured with a 7-point Likert scale (1=strongly disagree to 7=strongly agree). Brand equity (composite reliability=.77), found to be unidimensional, was created by totaling and averaging the five items.

Control variables-altruistic volunteerism -Importantly, some literature suggests a dimension of an individual's support behavior toward nonprofit organizations is influenced by an altruistic tendency to become involved in or volunteer with nonprofits (e.g., Carlo et al. 1991, p. 450). These authors define altruism "as voluntary behavior not motivated by the expectation of external rewards or by the avoidance of aversive external stimuli." Additionally, volunteering is significantly affected by an individual's general compassion and desire to help and is not necessarily related to a situational drive (Carlo et al. 1991; Unger 1991). Since the portion of biased support behavior toward the nonprofit explained by this altruistic dimension of volunteerism is not a direct outcome of brand marketing efforts, volunteerism is treated as a control variable in the hierarchical regression procedure. The analysis will focus on the remaining dimensions subject to marketing efforts. The items to measure volunteerism were adapted from scales suggested by Wells and Tigert (1971) and Yavas and Riechen (1985). Volunteerism as a control was operationalized with two variables. The first one item factor, *activciv*, suggested the respondent's past volunteering activity. The second factor, *volunteer*, created by totaling and averaging the two items, measured the attitude toward volunteering (composite reliability=.71).

Measure Validities

Overall Model Fit

The AMOS output furnishes a number of measures which allow assessment of the absolute and incremental fit of the proposed model (see Table 2). In the model a chi-square of 550.6 (df=284, $p<.01$) was observed. This suggested poor model fit, but is a common result (Hair et al. 1998). Another overall goodness of fit measure that accounts for sample size is the root mean square of approximation (RMSEA). Values in the .05 to .08 range are suggested to be acceptable by Browne and Cudeck (1993). This model with an RMSEA of .072 is deemed to be acceptable.

AMOS also provides several incremental fit measures of goodness of fit (see Table 2). These measures compare the relevant proposed model to a baseline model (Hair et al.

1998). First, a normed chi-square up to 5.0 is said to be acceptable. The normed chi-square observed here of 1.94 is acceptable by this criterion. Additionally, incremental fit measures close to .95 for NFI and CFI are cited as indication of acceptable fit (Hu and Bentler 1999); other measures are assumed to follow. The following measures meet the .95 criteria: NFI=.96, CFI=.98, IFI=.98 and RFI=.95. Based upon this evidence it seems reasonable to conclude the overall model has achieved acceptable goodness of fit.

Measurement Model Fit

The measurement model results are seen in Tables 2 and 3. Construct (composite) reliability, a measure of the internal consistency of the dependent and independent constructs uses measures greater than .60 as the rule of thumb for acceptable consistency (Bagozzi and Yi 1988). The following results were obtained for the composite constructs: brand equity (.77), brand respect (.80), brand differentiation (.67), brand character (.89), brand scale (.58), and familiarity (.90). Even though brand scale fell slightly below the .60 criteria, since this is exploratory research it can be surmised that all measures achieved adequate reliability.

In addition to acceptable construct reliability indicated by the above cited results, construct validity requires convergent and discriminant validity be achieved. Convergent validity was suggested through confirmatory factor analysis which indicated all observed items loaded significantly ($p < .01$) on the appropriate latent construct. Discriminant validity can be determined by several measures. One method, variance extraction test, is performed by squaring the correlations between any two latent constructs and comparing the result to the variance extracted for the involved constructs. Discriminant validity is indicated if the variance extracted is greater than the squared correlations (Fornell and Larcker 1981). Discriminant validity is suggested in each case because the variance extracted exceeds the appropriate squared correlation. Another measure for discriminant validity offered by Anderson and Gerbing (1988) examines the confidence interval around the correlations between latent constructs (correlation plus/minus 2 times the standard error). If the confidence interval does not include the value one, discriminant validity is supported. Examination of the resulting confidence intervals indicates none that included the value one. Thus, discriminant validity is also supported by this method. The overall examination for discriminant validity suggests the constructs used in this research are empirically and conceptually distinct. It would appear the model has achieved adequate reliability and convergent and discriminant validity.

Data Analysis

In the initial data analysis confirmatory factor analysis using AMOS (SEM software) was used for scale purification and examination of overall model fit and the measurement model.

The examination followed the 1st Stage of the Anderson and Gerbing (1988) Two Stage Model. Since the research was exploratory in nature, the structural analysis in the 2nd Stage was not utilized. Next, the hypotheses were analyzed with hierarchical multiple regression. This technique allowed simultaneous evaluation of the hypothesized influence of brand personality, brand image, and brand awareness dimensions on nonprofit brand equity while controlling for the effect of altruistic volunteerism. Hierarchical regression was considered appropriate because all the measures achieved adequate reliability (Hair et al. 1998).

RESULTS

Regression Assumptions

A regression model requires compliance with assumptions of normality, linearity, collinearity, and homoscedasticity. Normality of the standardized residual was tested with a Kolmogorov-Smirnov (Lilliefors Significance Correction) statistic. The results suggested normality ($p > .05$). Examination of a P-P Plot and scatterplot of the dependent variable, Brand Equity, indicated a linear model. While some of the measure correlations reached .50, consideration of the collinearity diagnostics indicated no Condition Index greater than 30 or VIF greater than 1.9, thus, collinearity was not detected (Neter, Wasserman, and Kutner 1990; Hair et al. 1998). Finally, a regression standardized residual vs. regression standardized predicted value scatterplot revealed no non-random pattern of points, indicating homoscedasticity. Thus, it can be concluded the model met all regression assumption requirements.

Hypothesis Testing

The results of the hierarchical regression analysis used to test for the influence of the dimensions of brand personality, brand image, and brand awareness on the dependent variable, resource provider based nonprofit brand equity, are provided in Table 4. Overall, nonprofit brand equity was significantly influenced by the set of antecedent variables ($F = 22.5$; $p < .01$). Additionally, a significant amount of incremental variance ($R^2 = .279$) in nonprofit brand equity was provided by the antecedents after controlling for altruistic volunteerism. Following are the results of the individual hypotheses.

H1a and H1b examined for the influence of brand personality dimensions, brand respect and brand differentiation, on nonprofit brand equity. Brand respect ($B = .259$, $P < .05$) and brand differentiation ($B = .258$, $P < .05$) were both significant influences. Respondents who respected the nonprofit and viewed it as different from other nonprofits were more interested in providing resources (biased support behavior) to the nonprofit. Thus, H1a and H1b are supported. In H2a and H2b it was hypothesized that the brand image dimensions of brand character and brand scale would influence nonprofit brand equity. The results indicate brand character did not

TABLE 2
CONFIRMATORY FACTOR ANALYSIS

Latent Variable	Factory Description	Factory Indicator	Loading	t-stat	Composite Reliability	Variance Extracted		
Brand Personality	Brand respect	Admirarc	.80	*	.80	.57		
		Proudarc	.76	10.25				
		Trustacr	.73	9.71				
	Brand differentiation	Cleararc	.68	*	.67	.51		
		Diffearc	.54	5.73				
		Histoarc	.71	6.91				
Brand Image	Brand character	Modest	.57	*	.89	.62		
		Contempo	.48	5.50				
		Thrifty	.58	6.34				
		Brave	.78	7.66				
		Kind	.82	7.89				
		Valuable	.83	7.95				
		Honest	.67	7.01				
	Brand scale	Dominati	.38	*	.58	.45		
		Exciting	.67	4.08				
		Large	.52	3.79				
		Rich	.46	3.58				
Brand Awareness	Familiarity	Familiar	.79	3.66	.90	.75		
		Highinf	.86	3.70				
		Knowgrea	.93	3.72				
		Relknow	.57	3.46				
Brand Equity	Brand equity	Joinlike	.78	*	.77	.47		
		Joinprob	.80	9.32				
		Joinposs	.54	6.64				
		Paylarge	.45	5.57				
		Valuearc	.43	5.31				
* Value set to 1								
Goodness of Fit Statistics								
Chi-Square	df	P	RMSEA	Normed Chi-Ssquare	NFI	CFI	IFI	RFI
550.6	284	.000	.072	1.94	0.96	0.98	0.98	0.95

TABLE 3
CONSTRUCT MEANS, STANDARD DEVIATIONS, AND CORRELATION MATRIX
(S.E. in parentheses)

Construct Variable	Mean	S.D.	VIF	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
(1)Brand respect	5.51	1.18	1.90	1					
(2)Brand differentiation	3.81	1.14	1.40	.38(.13)	1				
(3)Brand character	5.51	.95	1.80	.57(.11)	.23(.10)	1			
(4)Brand scale	4.19	1.01	1.40	.37(.09)	.50(.13)	.21(.06)	1		
(5)Familiarity	3.07	1.71	1.33	.38(.10)	.34(.13)	.40(.09)	.33(.08)	1	
(6)Brand Equity	3.11	1.13		.51(.13)	.48(.16)	.31(.10)	.39(.10)	.18(.10)	1

All correlations significant at the .01 level (2-tailed)

TABLE 4
HIERARCHICAL REGRESSION RESULTS
RESOURCE PROVIDED BASED BRAND EQUITY

Treatment Variable	Model w/Controls				Model w/Antecedents			
	Unstandardized Coefficient	t-Stat	S.E.	Beta	Unstandardized Coefficient	t-Stat	S.E.	Beta
Volunteer	.372***	6.657	.056	.436	.255***	5.436	.047	.299
Active	.113***	2.728	.042	.179	.105***	3.004	.035	.165
Brand Respect					.259***	3.635	.071	.265
Brand Differentiation					.253***	4.125	.061	.260
Brand Character					.126*	1.502	.084	.107
Brand Scale					.183***	2.516	.073	.158
First Recall					.149	1.053	.141	.058
Familiarity					-.133***	-3.235	.041	-.199
Cumulative R ²	.230				.508			
F	26.813***				22.465***			
Degrees of Freedom	2/180				8/174			
Incremental R ²					.279			
F					16.422***			
Degrees of Freedom								

N=183; *p<.10; **p<.05; ***p<.01

produce a significant effect on nonprofit brand equity ($B=.09$, $P<.10$) but brand scale ($B=.141$, $P<.05$) did. This suggests that respondents who believe the nonprofit exhibited brand character were not more interested in providing resources to the nonprofit, but those who believed the nonprofit had brand scale did exhibit biased support behavior. Thus, H2a was not supported, but H2b was. Finally, brand awareness exhibited mixed significance. First recall was not significant ($B=.046$, $P>.10$). Thus, respondents who had first recall of the nonprofit were not more interested in providing resources to the nonprofit. On the other hand, respondents who were familiar with the nonprofit were significantly unwilling to provide resources to the nonprofit ($B= -.177$, $P<.05$), a counterintuitive finding. Thus, H3a and H3b are not supported.

DISCUSSION

This is the first reported research to empirically apply the brand equity construct to the nonprofit sector and examine antecedent factors which influence increasingly constrained resource providers to behave in a biased manner to nonprofits (volunteer, donate, join, etc), when controlling for an individual's internal altruistic tendency to volunteer. Several significant antecedent effects of the variables were observed. When brand personality is framed in terms of a relationship between the nonprofit and resource provider, the dimensions of a respectable and different organization were the most significant influences on the resource providers' willingness to behave toward or support the focal organization. The brand image dimensions of nonprofit brand character and scale produced mixed results. Nonprofit brand character was not found to exert a significant influence on resource provider

decisions, but those decisions were influenced by the perception the nonprofit was of a certain scale. The effect of brand awareness exhibited mixed significance and a counterintuitive, but explicable result. One traditional dimension of brand awareness, first recall, did not significantly influence resource provider decisions, but a second dimension, familiarity, had a significant counterintuitive negative influence on resource provider decisions. In this instance, it appeared resource providers may not have been supportive of the focal organization because of negative perceptions held.

The findings add to the literature in three ways: 1) the efficacy of a brand equity approach in the nonprofit sector is suggested; 2) multidimensional antecedent influences on resource provider based brand equity are suggested; and 3) utilization of the model potentially provides the basis for relationship building between resource providers and nonprofits.

The brand equity construct has gained increased utilization in the for-profit sector, where firms have frequently been persuaded of its potential role in managing consumer behavior toward their important brand assets. Until now, nonprofits faced with critical resource challenges, have had no empirical evidence of how the construct might apply to their sector. This exploratory research suggests brand equity may be a relatively robust construct and has potential efficacy in the nonprofit context.

The findings also contribute to the nonprofit brand equity literature by providing indications of the multidimensional influence of resource provider based brand equity antecedents. The extant nonprofit brand equity literature is solely practitioner and nonprofit managers have occasionally been encouraged to implement brand equity models without empirical evidence the decision making of resource constrained resource providers will be positively influenced. Previous for-profit center research (Keller 1993; Aaker 1996; Aaker 1997; Fournier 1998) reported the multidimensionality, but had not empirically examined these influences in brand equity models. Brand awareness and brand image have previously received much of the attention as brand equity antecedents (Keller 1993). By conceptualizing brand awareness solely as recall/recognition, Keller (1993) may have missed a critical familiarity dimension that while found to be negative, was nonetheless significant. This finding, which is consistent with the Churchill and Iacobucci (2002) characterization of a familiarity dimension of brand awareness, enhances our conceptual understanding of this critical component of brand equity and suggests it is not always just whether we can recall something, but the depth of our understanding. Interestingly, this research provides preliminary evidence that brand personality, frequently included as a dimension of brand image (Keller 1993; Aaker 1996), has a multidimensional independent effect on brand equity. Operationalization of the Fournier (1998) relationship framed brand personality construct allowed the research to identify dimensions of brand respect and differentiation which

influence resource providers to develop biased support behavior toward the nonprofit brand/organization. In particular, this research suggests the predominant focus in the literature on brand personality as human traits (Aaker 1997) needs to be considered along with the relationship framed brand personality perspective espoused by Fournier (1998). In fact, what this research has at least partially accomplished is operationalize and link streams of marketing literature, the groundbreaking brand equity work of Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993) with some richer conceptualizations of its antecedents (Malhotra 1981; Aaker 1997; Fournier 1998; Churchill and Iacobucci 2002).

Research Limitations and Future Research

This research looked at the brand equity of a specific nonprofit, which may not be completely representative of all nonprofits. For example, clearly the negative influence of familiarity suggests the results may be partially an artifact of the organization studied. Aaker (1991) indicated constructs other than image and awareness positively affect brand equity. Specifically, he suggested the effect perceived quality, brand loyalty, and other brand assets exert on brand equity. Inclusion of these omitted variables and variables not suggested in the brand equity literature, such as, financial and professional benefits accruing to resource providers and the influence of the nonprofit's mission could have changed the significance or relative importance of those antecedents which were included.

The research limitations should be addressed in future research. Specifically, a broader range of nonprofit types should be studied and omitted variables could be included. Additionally, researchers should continue to look at brand personality and address the issues raised by Aaker (1997) and Fournier (1998) and those who feel it has an independent influence on brand equity outside any influence as an element of brand image. Finally, the exploratory research results have helped to better identify a more cohesive theory that might be examined through structural equation modeling. Generalization of the results to the nonprofit population awaits addressing the study limitations through the suggested research agenda.

Managerial implications

The results of this study suggest the relevance of the brand equity construct as a tool for managers in nonprofit organizations coping with scarce resources. Specifically, the results indicated biased decision making by resource providers (nonprofit brand equity) can potentially be influenced by considering its antecedents, the personality and image characteristics of the organization, and how familiar consumers are with the organization. This is important to nonprofit managers who spend approximately half their time trying to influence the decision making of increasingly constrained resource providers. It appears that management of the antecedents may be the essential benefit of the brand

equity concept, because to focus on brand equity consequences first is putting the cart before the horse. It is the brand equity antecedents that require development and nurture by nonprofit managers. Ultimately, attention to the antecedents may permit the development of stronger relationships and resource provider support. This may distinguish nonprofits marketing to resource providers who do not necessarily receive the tangible reward of a product or service which is inherent in the for-profit consumer-based brand equity model. For example, the focal nonprofit in this study subsequently developed its first marketing plan and integrated brand equity and its antecedents as guiding objectives.

While the research indicated the potential efficacy and importance of integrating the brand equity construct and its components with the nonprofit literature, it also demonstrated the need to consider managing the multiple dimensions of the antecedent constructs. The literature had theorized the antecedents of brand equity were multidimensional, a notion supported by this research. This finding becomes a potential contributor to the design of nonprofit marketing efforts. It is not sufficient to know that building positive brand personality and image increase supportive behavior toward the organization. Marketing efforts might consider that brand image enhancement will be predicated on developing and nurturing positive image components and avoiding indications the nonprofit's current organizational scale makes it a bad candidate for assistance and support. An illustration of how the findings can be used is shown by the focal nonprofit's development of one television advertising spot. This spot concentrated on the brand personality dimension of a different nonprofit to distinguish it from the other nonprofits marketing to the same potential resource providers.

The results support consideration of brand personality as a construct practically separate from brand image. Brand personality may be developed and nurtured separate from brand image. Building strong and positive brand personalities may provide the basis for a relationship with resource providers and build positive bias and support for the nonprofit. This highlights the importance of not relying exclusively on

one time annual fund raising. The focal nonprofit believed upon viewing the results that they needed to connect more intimately with resource providers and started using their actual clients in a very thoughtful communication effort. They wanted potential resource providers to know they could enter into a relationship with real people, not some rich bureaucracy. This construct helps to answer the question resource providers frequently pose; is this an organization that I am comfortable entering into a relationship with and does it stand for the things I stand for? The marketing efforts can build on the brand personality associations consumers respect and relate to, but the efforts should distinguish the nonprofit from other nonprofits. Competitive markets demand the organization be respected, but differentiated. The results' implications in regards to the brand awareness construct are perhaps more ambiguous than those previously noted. Previous research has consistently described the significance of brand awareness measures in brand equity research. This research indicated insignificance for top of mind recall by respondents when cued to the nonprofit category. The results should not be interpreted to suggest recall is unimportant, past research suggests it is, but just focusing on consumer recall as the key link to building brand equity might be misdirected. The effect of the other significant dimension of brand awareness, familiarity, also may be carefully considered. The results suggested a negative influence on brand equity. In other words, the empirical results suggested the more familiar respondents were with the nonprofit being studied, the less likely they were to be positively biased toward the organization. This seems to contradict the conventional notion that familiarity should enhance brand equity. Thus, it should be considered that the respondents might have held some negative perceptions of the organization and as the perceived familiarity of the organization increased, its negative effect on support behavior toward the organization became more manifest. One implication to marketing managers is to be certain of positive perceptions of the organization before undertaking awareness building campaigns. Otherwise, the marketing efforts may have the net effect of growing and nurturing the public's negative perceptions.

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